

KENYATTA UNIVERSITY
DEPARTMENT OF RELIGIOUS STUDIES

ARE 100: Introduction to African Religious Heritage (ARH)

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Lesson One

Meaning of African Religious Heritage: African identity

Appendix 1

1.0 Introduction

In this course, I plan to introduce you to **African Religious**, and **Cultural Heritage**. This course is hoped to make African Religion more practical, useful, and meaningful to all students who go through it.

In the first lesson, I am going to define African Religion and the major difficulties encountered in trying to define it. I will also describe the reasons for such difficulties. The handicaps in defining African Religion are crucial to the understanding of African Religious **worldview**.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Define African Religious and Cultural Heritage
- Analyze the difficulties in defining African Religious Heritage.
- Explain the reasons that lead to the problem of definition.

Appendix 3

Content:

African Religion and Culture comprises of the beliefs and practices of the African peoples about God, Nature and the **Universe**.

Note:

There are several difficulties encountered in trying to define African religion. Due to the ambiguity in the definition, people often talk of it in plural.

The reasons for the difficulties in defining ARH are:

- (i) Diversity of African Cultures and the peoples
- (ii) Geographical extent of the continent of Africa
- (iii) External influence
- (iv) Confusion of **sacred** and **secular**

We find that due to the existence of several ethnic groups in Africa, who have variances in beliefs and practices, it becomes difficult to speak of an African religion in the singular. Moreover, physical barriers like deserts, mountains, and rivers seem to divide the African continent into geographical enclaves. The history of the continent further enhances the divisions into Africa in times of slave trade, colonialism, apartheid, neo-colonialism and more recently globalization, strife/war-torn, debt ridden and HIV/Aids affected Africa.

Note:

Despite all these factors, we find the concept referred to as “negritude”. This concept illustrates the “Africanness” (commonness) found in all peoples of African descent. It is a thread that knits through the beliefs and practices of African peoples.

Its importance leads us to speak of African Religion as one in spite of the various dimensions.

Appendix 4

Question:

Why should Africans study African Religion?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Suggest three different communities in Kenya. Find out any common cultural beliefs and practices among them.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lecture, we have looked into the meaning and difficulties of the study of ARH. We have seen that, it has been rather difficult to define ARH due to the diversity of the peoples and the cultures. We have noted that, although Africans have different ethnic affiliations, their beliefs and practices especially in relation to the concept of God are quite similar. African religious ideas are spread throughout the continent and outside among all peoples of African descent and they indicate some similarities.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Sacred - that which concerns the Holy, God and all that is not worldly.

Secular- that which concerns the world; the opposite of the Holy.

Negritude- commonness of African peoples and cultures

Universe- this describes the world and all that is in it.

Worldview- a peoples' perception of the world.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Idowu, E. B (1973) African Traditional Religion: A Definition: SCM Press Ltd, London.

Mbiti, J. S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann, London.

Mugambi, J.N.K. (1989) African Heritage and Contemporary Christianity, Nairobi.

Lesson Two

Elements of African Religious Heritage

Appendix I

Introduction

In the previous lesson, we looked into the meaning of ARH, the difficulties in understanding it and the reasons for those difficulties. In today's lesson, I am going to describe the elements ARH. I will also describe the relevance of these elements and how they help us to understand the components of ARH.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Give the elements of African Religion
- Describe these elements in relation to African Religious Heritage.
- Analyze their importance in understanding ARH.

Appendix 3

Content:

There are five fundamental elements of African Religion and Culture. These are:

- (i) Belief in God
- (ii) Belief in the **divinities**
- (iii) Belief in the **spirits**
- (iv) Belief in **ancestors**
- (v) Practice of **magic** and medicine

Religion in Africa is **holistic**. It is connected with all life from the time before birth to death and even thereafter. Life is one religious whole. A person lives in a community, which incorporates the living, the unborn, and the departed (dead).

Note:

There is a spiritual understanding of life where all happenings such as diseases, drought, famine, good harvest, rains, etc. are interpreted as having a spiritual cause. There is a close connection between the visible and the invisible worlds.

There are spiritual forces of many different kinds at work in the world.

Life is often seen as a natural pattern and a rhythm, which is repeated, daily, seasonally, and annually; in endless cycles that come and go; hence, life would simply never end.

Spirits and divinities act as intermediaries between people and God, where magic and medicine are used to restore life and ward off disaster. **Myths** and **rituals** are important forms of expressions of religious life. The elders mainly spread these as they educate the youth on the important cycle of life.

Note:

It is important to note that oral tradition in Africa is important because aspects of religion and cultural heritage have been passed down from one generation to the other. Words or actions in oral history help transmit various elements of African beliefs and practices, which in most cases are unquestionable.

Appendix 4

Question:

What is the role of spirits and divinities in African communities?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Select six elders from your community (both males and females). Find out from them, their perception of both misfortunes and good luck.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have looked into the elements of ARH. We have seen that, Africa religion is comprised of five fundamental elements. Religion is holistic and life is sacred. We have noted that, life is a continuous endless cycle of events that come and go. In conclusion, we have also noted that, in ARH good health is attributed to God's blessings where misfortunes are a sign of God's punishment.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Ancestors- departed elders of African communities.

Divinities- spirits with divine powers that act as intermediaries between humans and God.

Spirits-souls of departed members of the community.

Myths -fanciful stories concerning the origin and destiny of the world, life and humans.

Rituals-actions performed in religious ceremonies and associated with certain beliefs

Holistic- totality of life.

Magic- the practice of mysterious powers by special people referred to as magicians.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Mbiti, J. S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann, London

Parrider, E.G. (1974) African Traditional Religion: Sheldon Press: London

Lesson Three

Sources of ARH

Appendix I

Introduction

In the previous lesson, we looked into the elements of ARH, their importance in understanding our religion and cultural heritage. In today's lesson, I want to discuss the sources of ARH. Having no sacred texts, African Religion is found in various aspects of daily lives, living and non-living objects in Africa.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Identify the various sources of ARH.
- Describe where you can find African Religion

Appendix 3

Content:

There are several sources of African Religion and Culture. These are:

- (a) Languages- naming systems.
- (b) Social structure
- (c) Religious persons
- (d) Worship
- (e) Oral traditions
- (f) Art
- (g) Literally works

Africa religion is found in various aspects. The language of a people tells us about the sacred, for example the naming systems. -God, people, places, events etc Places and events are mainly given names that tell much about their sacredness. **Kinship** and political systems often describe beliefs that people often have about religion and cultural importance. Most communities in Africa have religious specialists, who in essence portray the peoples' religious ideas. These "holy" people are the authorities of prayers, **rituals** and **sacrifices** that are often carried out at different places and times, which often describe the peoples' attitudes towards God.

Note:

Oral traditions play a vital role as a source of ideas about God and the sacred. In essence, proverbs, myths, legends, customs and taboos are rich sources of beliefs and practices of different African communities. These mostly tell much about a community's religious worldview.

African music and dance, rhythms and the work of art, in either paintings or sculptor, also show the ideas that African peoples hold about the sacred. More recently, is the subject of religion as often portrayed in written work, be it fiction or reading texts.

Note:

African religion does not have sacred books, unlike most world religions. However, religion is often seen and interpreted from various circumstances and experiences of the African peoples.

Oral tradition in Africa is important because aspects of religion and cultural heritage have been passed down from one generation to the other. Words or actions in oral history become important sources of African beliefs and practices.

Appendix 4

Question:

Are there any aspects/objects in your community that serve as sources of African religion? Identify and describe what aspects of religion they portray.

Appendix 5

Activity:

List all your African names (including nicknames). Find out their meaning(s). Are there any unusual circumstances surrounding your birth? Find out the connection between this and any of your names?

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have looked into the sources of ARH. We have seen that, African religion is basically found in our surroundings, circumstances and events that surround us. We have observed that, names, events, actions, and places that seem ordinary to an outsider may have deep religious interpretation to the African peoples.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Kinship-relations by blood, marriage and adoption

Proverbs-sayings in a community that carries some hidden wisdom

Taboos- ritualistic prohibitions in a society

Sanctuaries-holy places

Sacrifices- animal offerings often directed to God

Legends-stories narrated about the origin of events or heroic people

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Idowu, E. B (1973) African Traditional Religion: A Definition: SCM Press Ltd, London

Mbiti, J. S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann, London

Lesson Four

Afrotheism: Concept of God in Africa

Appendix I

Introduction

In our last discussion, we looked into the sources of ARH. We noted that the sources are important in understanding our religion and cultural heritage. We also pointed out the importance of oral history as a source of ARH. In today's lesson, I want to address the concept of God in Africa. God is a reality in all-African communities and by analyzing the concept, we understand His nature, qualities and characteristics. Most of what we know about God is found besides other things in the names given to Him and their meaning.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Identify several names of God in Africa.
- Interpret and give the meanings of the names of God.

Appendix 3

Content:

God is a reality in every traditional society in Africa. God needs no explanation and most ideas about Him are learnt almost by instinct. His character and personality are often understood through His various names. Examples of God's names are *Nyasae*, *Were*, *Enkai*, *Ngai*, *Mwathani*, *Murungu*, *Muumbi*, *Engoro*, *Ogun*, *Oludumare*, *Nyame* etc.

Note:

Most names run across one or several communities. These names describe God's nature and works. Most name(s) often indicate an only God, not shared, a Supreme Being.

God is mainly associated with the sky, sun, and other **celestial** bodies, which in essence, indicate, oneness with the universe and in creation. Other names of God that are qualified portray Him as merciful, kind, just etc. These portray a caring and nurturing aspect of God, which is only unique to Him.

African ideas about God are also perceived through myths, proverbs and other forms of oral literature.

Appendix 4

Question:

Find out the communities, which use the above names of God.

What are their meanings?

What is the name(s) of God in your community?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Identify two communities in Africa. List all the names of God in these communities. Find out the meanings of these names and how they help one understand the nature of God.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have looked into the nature of God in Africa. We have seen that, God is a reality in Africa who is known by all peoples within a community. We learn most of God's nature from his various names, some of which are shared by neighboring ethnic groups. Most names portray his characteristics of supremacy. God is also perceived as a spirit, and although He is not visible, his attributes make him a reality.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Afrotheism- study of God in Africa

Supreme-mighty and above everything else

Celestial- objects associated with the sky like the sun, moon, stars etc

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Gehman, K.J. (1983) Africa Religion in Biblical Perspective: E.A.P.H. Nairobi

Idowu, B.B. (1973), Africa Traditional Religion: A definition: SCM Press Ltd, London

Kenyatta, J. (1938) Facing Mount Kenya: Secker and Warburg, London

Mbiti, J.S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann. London

Lesson Five

Nature of God: Part One

Appendix I

Introduction

In our last discussion, we looked into the concept of God in Africa. The purpose was to understand the perception of God in African religion. We noted that most of our ideas about God are understood through His names. In the current lesson, I want to address the

attributes of God. In analyzing His attributes, we understand His nature. By so doing, we shall be able to conceptualize most of African beliefs and practices. Besides names, most ideas about God in Africa are learnt through proverbs and myths. These explain the nature of God.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Describe the nature of God in Africa.
- Identify and explain the proverbs that relate to God.
- Explain our understanding of God from His nature.

Appendix 3

Content:

God in Africa is often described in the following terms:

- Omniscient - all knowing, all seeing, all watching
- Omnipresent - all round, everywhere
- Omnipotent - almighty can do everything, nothing defeats God.
- Transcendent - powerful and above human's power
- Immanent - close to us and able to help us (has long arms and near to reach us when He wishes. (God, though transcendent is never too far away to reach us).

Note:

Although Africans consider God in transcendental terms, above human reach, His attribute of being immanent, make Him close to the people. He is perceived to be near all the times to assist the humans.

Appendix 4

Question:

What do we learn about God's nature from the above attributes?

Appendix 5

Activity:

List any three proverbs related to God in Africa. Find out their meanings and how they illustrate the nature of God as shown above.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we note that God in Africa is perceived to be Supreme, all knowing and everywhere. Due to these attributes, African religion is ranked as monotheistic. God is ready to reach people and they see Him as a caring and only God. His presence among the people at all times and places help the human beings to go through the hustles of life.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Monotheism: worship of an only God

Monotheistic: refers to nature of an only God

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Idowu, E.B., (1961) Oludumare, God in Yoruba Belief: SCM Press Ltd, London

Kenyatta, J. (1938) Facing Mount Kenya: Secker and Warburg, London

Mbiti, J.S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann. London

Mbiti, J.S (1970) Concepts of God in Africa: Heinemann. London

Lesson six

Nature of God: Part Two

Appendix I

Introduction

In our last discussion, we looked into some of the attributes of God in Africa. The aim was to analyze the attributes of God in order to understand His nature. This understanding is important in the perception of African religion. In the current lesson, I want to discuss more attributes that also describe His nature. In analyzing the nature of God, we shall be able to conceptualize most of African beliefs and practices.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Describe the attributes of God in Africa.
- Explain the nature of God from His attributes.
- Explain our understanding of God from His nature.

Appendix 3

Content:

God in Africa is often described in the following terms:

- Self-existent - not created, does not live in time, exists alone, and is self-independent. He alone is God.
- External and everlasting - ever living from the beginning was, is, and is to come.
- Great and supreme - ruler, governor, father and authority.
- Creator - **Moulder**, mother, gives birth, raises, protects, originator of families, fashioner. God is said to have created out of nothing or at times, used creation materials (mainly soil and water).
- Savior- protector - Gives safety and protection. Cannot forsake helper of the poor (nourishes and provider of food rain).
- Merciful - acts at his own will, is not influenced.

Note:

Although Africans consider God as a Great Spirit, they describe him in human terms because of his attributes. He is the greatest spirit, elder whose love is experienced daily. He deserves all respect. He is not expected to be partial. He dwells in the sky and His supremacy and immensity are associated with natural occurrences.

Appendix 4

Question:

What do we learn about God's nature from the above?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Find out the attributes of God in your community. What do these tell you about your community's perception of God?

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we learn from the attributes of God in Africa that He is merciful and kind. Due to his caring attributes, people relate to him at personal levels and cling to Him in times of needs. Despite His Spiritual nature, God is also seen in human terms, at times even as a mother. These nurturing attributes provide that vital link of dependency that humans have with God.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Moulder: the art of making and shaping an object, mostly using clay, for example the making of pots.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Idowu, E.B., (1961) Oludumare, God in Yoruba Belief: SCM Press Ltd, London

Kenyatta, J. (1938) Facing Mount Kenya: Secker and Warburg, London

Mbiti, J.S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann. London

Mbiti, J.S (1970) Concepts of God in Africa: Heinemann. London

Lesson seven

Works of God in Africa

Appendix I

Introduction

In lessons five and six above, we analyzed the attributes of God in Africa. The aim was to understand the nature of God in Africa. From His attributes we observed that although God is often seen as a Great Spirit, He is also described in human terms. As such, people in Africa are able to relate with God. Moreover, we learnt, God is both far (transcendent), but also very near to assist Africans in times of need. In this lesson, I want to address the existence and works of God in African religion and cultural heritage. In this, I will look into how God's existence is manifested through His works among human beings.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Describe the works of God.

- Explain the existence of God through His works
- Illustrate how we experience God through his works.

Appendix 3

Content:

Mythology portrays human beings as having been created first and given relevant work to do. This work is related to a community's needs. Celestial phenomena act as **symbols** of God's work on earth. The environment shapes God's image. Nature and the geography of a people affect and influence the stories told about God in relation to mountains, deserts, cold places, waters etc. However, physical environment does not predetermine a person's beliefs concerning God. It only colors them. Beliefs and practices in Africa assume **divergent** shapes in the wide-open spaces of valleys, mountains, deserts, rivers and lakes. Similarly, social organizations are also reflected in religious beliefs and practices. Most African communities have different views about the trees, rocks, and caves, mountains, earthquakes, rain/rivers - sun/moon - animals, thunder, lighting, places and events. Africa acknowledges the dwelling place of God to be in the environment. God is the first to exist and He is immortal. If He died, then the world would collapse. However, since He is **immortal**, the world is unending. God is of providence, a source of 'mana', stronger than the power of magic and witchcraft. He cannot destroy the universe since it serves as an indicator of His existence. It is a sign of His creation and manifestation.

Note:

For the Africans, the presence of natural phenomena is an indication of God's wonders and existence. He communicates to the people sometimes, through occurrences in the universe, all, which serves as God's imprints on earth.

Appendix 4

Question:

What are some of the objects that remind you of God's existence?

Appendix 5

Activity

Select a cross-section of ten people in your community (children, men and women). Find out from them what images they have about God and how they experience His existence.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we note that God in Africa is known through His various works. Most works of God are a manifestation of His existence. Africans have a whole range of experiences about God, all which they learn from His contact with their environment. This often shapes their concept about God.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Divergent: widely distributed, vast; taking different directions

Immortal: everlasting, unending, would not die

Symbols: objects or signs used to represent something.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Idowu, B.B. (1973), Africa Traditional Religion: A definition: SCM Press Ltd, London

Kenyatta, J. (1938) Facing Mount Kenya: Secker and Warburg, London

Mbiti, J.S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann. London

Njinya L. , Peace Habomugisa et.al. (eds.) (1997) Gods and Ghosts: Traditional Religion in Buganda and Bunyoro: A Special "Journal of African Religion and Philosophy".

JARP& John O'Donohoe, Uppsala University. Sweden

Lesson Eight

Worship in Africa

Appendix I

Introduction

In the last lesson we discussed the existence and works of God in African Religion and Cultural Heritage. In today's lesson, I will address the subject of worship in African beliefs. Previously, we have observed that, God is available for the Africans as they experience their day to day activities. However, though God is ever present, there are mysterious forces that are beyond human power. Humans are **vulnerable** to these powers, and therefore, there is a constant need to **appease** God. I will discuss the need for worship in African religiosity.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Describe the need for worship in African religion
- Relate the separation of humans with the concept of worship in African religion

Appendix 3

Content

From Africa myths of creation, we learn that human beings were originally created to enjoy a certain prestigious position in God's plan. This is the gift of immortality, **rejuvenation** after old age, and continuous supply of food (providence) from God. However, mythology illustrates how certain human activities, behavior and or attitudes affected the glorious relationship between the humans and God. Consequently, God withdrew from the people. Besides other forms of suffering, stories told about the fall describe death as the severest punishment that humans got from the fall. As such, Africans have a need to find a way of restoring the lost relationship with God.

Worship is therefore done to:

- Maintain peace and harmony with God
- Counter the evil in the world
- Obtain peace with fellow humans.

Note:

The fall made Africans vulnerable to suffering, the worst being death. As a result, there is a constant need for worship. The reason is to attempt to restore the broken relationship, as well as maintain peace and harmony with the self , God, and other creation.

Note:

Worship in Africa exists as a way of life with prayers, offerings, and sacrifices being quite common. Sacrifices comprise of burnt animals which are of specific qualities. In rare cases, human sacrifice was applicable.

Appendix 4

Questions:

Why do you think human beings have a constant need to worship God?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Talk to several elders in your community. Ask them the reasons that led people to worship and sacrifice in African religion. Relate these to today's prayer requests in religious organizations. Are the reasons the same?

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have learnt that worship is away of life among African peoples. People feel obliged to worship and sacrifice to restore the broken relationship between humans and God. They also worship and sacrifice to counteract the problems they encounter in day to day living. These are problems that came after God's presence was withdrawn from us.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Appease: to please, persuade

Rejuvenation: the ability to remain young after old age

Vulnerable: weak and prone to attack

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Mbiti, J. S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann, London.

Ray, B.C. (1976) African Religions: Symbols and the Community: Prentice Hall Inc.
New Jersey

Lesson Nine

Types of Worship in Africa

Appendix I

Introduction

In the last lesson we discussed worship in African Religion and Cultural Heritage. We noted that, God's withdrawal from the world, and the presence of mysterious forces in the universe all render humans vulnerable. As such, there is a constant need for worship. In today's lesson, I will address the different forms of worship in African beliefs. Different needs call for the invocation of God in various aspects. This is due to the emptiness that humans feel as a result of God's absence.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Describe the different types of worship in African religion
- Analyze the types and nature of worship in Africa

Appendix 3

Content

Worship is a way of life, which incorporates prayers, **offerings** and **sacrifices**. The types of worship are:-

1. Formal- performed during initiation, marriage and death. It is also done at times of planting, harvesting, droughts, famine, and floods. The reason for the formal worship is to bring the community together in prayer to celebrate a rite of passage or appease God to avert disaster. These prayers are mainly organized and led by a religious specialist.
2. Informal- took place at home led by the head of a household. It included prayers for the "living-dead", sometimes a private prayer for the individual. These forms of prayers took place any time of the day and prayers were quite informal.

3. Regular- recitations on a daily basis. For example, the Nandi of Kenya, recites a routine prayer, "God guard for me the children, the cattle....."

4. Irregular-these were prayers conducted in times of crises.

In all forms of worship, the rituals were involved. The most important form of ritual was the sacrifice. Like other forms of worship, sacrifices varied in type and purpose. Mainly it was for atonement for murder, prevention of evil or danger, self denial and respect for God; substituting for others, gift for God, thanksgiving and restoring the broken relationships

Note:

Sacrifice was the highest form of worship in traditional Africa. It involved the pouring of blood of animals; and in specific cases, humans. Offerings on the other hand applied foods and drinks.

Note:

There were special times, places, and leadership in African worship. These depended on the nature of worship.

Appendix 4

Questions:

In your own opinion, why do you think sacrifices are important in Africa?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Select ten youth in your community. Get their views on the current forms of worship in contemporary Africa. Analyze these views in relation to the different forms of worship in Africa.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have discussed the forms of worship in Africa. From the analysis, we note that Africans worshiped at different times and occasions as need arose. The time, place and form of worship depended on its nature. Sacrifice was the highest form of worship in Africa.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Living-dead: departed members of the African community whom the living still remember by name.

Offerings: gifts of foods and drinks given to God.

Sacrifices: the killing of animal or human as a form of worship.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Mbiti, J. S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann, London.

Ray, B.C. (1976) African Religions: Symbols and the Community: Prentice Hall Inc. New Jersey

Lesson Ten

African Philosophical World View

Appendix I

Introduction

In lessons eight and nine, we discussed the need for worship and its various dimensions in African Religion. We analyzed the original plan of God for Human beings in creation, the fall and the subsequent consequences. In today's lesson, I want to discuss the underlying principles in African philosophy. By so doing, I want to show some elements in African religious worldview, which form the basis of some beliefs and practices.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Discuss African Religious worldview.
- Explain the principles of African philosophy
- Relate African philosophy with some beliefs and practices in Africa

Appendix 3

Content

African Worldview: this concept comprises of the underlying ideas and principles, which are given as governing peoples' rule of action or conduct. It explains the commonly accepted religious and cultural norms that are mostly accepted without criticism. These in due time become refereed to as customs.

African Philosophy: Chiefly concerned with ontology, i.e. the study of being and existence. It is **anthropocentric**. Life is therefore viewed in relation to the human being, and his/her relationship to life. In it, true humanity is achieved by the ability to share life through **procreation**; to be able to reach as many people as possible. This is achieved through the practice of polygamy, having as many children as possible and having a community-oriented generosity. The power to **procreate** is God given and only Him can

take it away. Magic and medicine can be manipulated either positively or negatively to create or destroy that power. As such, these become central elements in African religion since people have to continually protect themselves.

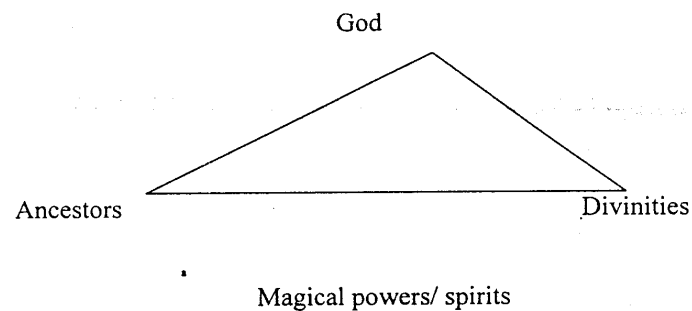
Common themes

- Belief in The Vital Power

There is a belief in some Power or Force or Vital energy that runs through the universe. This power is called "**mana**".

- Belief in God who is the cause of the force or 'mana' in the world. He controls it.
- Belief in the ability of spirits and special people to use that power.

The philosophy is summed up as a triangle; at the top, there is God. On either side are Ancestors or living dead and the divinities. At the base of the triangle, lie magical powers and spirits all, which may cause trouble to the humans.



Note:

Being at the center, humans are surrounded by various powers from all sides, which influence their lives. As such, there is a constant need to protect oneself from all these powers, hence, the practice of magic and witchcraft.

Appendix 4

Question:

Why do you think human beings are perceived to be at the center in African philosophy?

Appendix 5

Activity:

List six categories of the special people whom you think have the ability to use mana in your community. Find out in which ways they exercise their powers.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In the worldview, humans and God have profound meaning. God created the world and He continues creating. However, far away, humans are not far from the ancestors and the power of the spirits. Man/woman are part of a great living community and natural environment.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Anthropocentric-human centered.

Mana: impersonal mysterious power existing in the universe

Ontology: the study being and existence.

Procreation/procreate: the ability to give birth

Worldview: a general vision of the reality, an outlook of the way people perceive, understand, think, interpret the universe.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

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Lesson Eleven

Cosmology

Appendix I

Introduction

In the previous lesson, we discussed the underlying principles in African philosophy. Among these is the belief in mana, that force that runs within the universe. God, as we observed, is the source of this power. However, spirits and some humans have the ability to use it. In this lesson, I want to discuss the subject of cosmology. This refers to the images and doctrines concerning the universe. These are the perceptions and interpretations of the origin and destiny of the world. The study of the universe in African thought is important in understanding the principle ideas about God, origin, nature, and destiny of life.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Discuss the views that Africans hold about the universe
- Explain the importance of the universe in understanding African religious worldview.
- Analyze these images in relation to Africans perception of life and God.

Appendix 3

Content

Most religions of the world presuppose a view of the birth of the world, the cosmos. To understand the religious cosmological thought of any people, it is important to analyze their perception of the birth of the world. It is also vital to study their interrelationships and interpretations of the universe. This understanding often forms the basis of people's economical political, social, religious and cultural institutions.

In Africa the universe is viewed and interpreted as religious. Both man and woman live in a religious universe where natural phenomena and objects are intimately associated with God. These not only originate from Him but also bear witness of His presence. Each peoples' understanding of God is strongly colored by the universe in which they are themselves a part.

Note:

We see the universe not as the imprint, but the reflection of God; and whether that image is marred or clearly focused and defined, it is nevertheless an image of God, the only image sometimes known in traditional African societies.

To the African peoples, natural forces are interpreted and objects are perceived differently. For example, things to do with the following:-

- (i) Weather and its elements (sun, rain, moon stars, drought and floods, rainbow, thunder, lightening, vulcanicity, faulting) etc
- (ii) Animals like reptiles (snakes, chameleons, tortoises), mammals (hyenas, foxes, leopards) or even birds etc. have religious reflections to some ethnic groups.
- (iii) Sounds of animals , e.g. the owl, dog, some birds, insects, etc.
- (iv) Other objects like rocks, mountains, hills, springs, waterfalls etc.
- (v) Plants - certain holy and evil plants, (fig, sycamore,) etc.

Note:

The universe is a manifestation of God's immensity and power. It is an indicator of His work on earth.

Appendix 4

Question:

Why is the understanding the universe important to the Africans?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Give ten interpretations that your people use to associate the universe with certain beliefs.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have learnt the importance of the universe in understanding African religion. We find that certain natural objects bear witness of God's power and works that are continuous within the Universe. It is a religious universe, which is often, interpreted so. The environment they live in often colors the images that the Africans have about God.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Cosmology: the study of the universe

Marred: not clearly seen or focused

Universe: the world and all that is in it. In Africa, it includes the visible and the invisible.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

- Gelman, K.J. (1983) Africa Religion in Biblical Perspective: E.A.P.H. Nairobi
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Lesson Twelve

Ontology: Kinship Systems And Community

Appendix I

Introduction

In lesson eleven, we dealt with the African concept of the Universe. We discussed the images and doctrines concerning the universe, the perceptions and interpretations of the origin and destiny of the world. In today's discussion, I want us to analyze the kinship systems in Africa. We find that, kinship is the strongest bond of unity in most African communities.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Define and explain kinship bonds in Africa.
- Explain the relevance of kinship bonds in African culture.
- Discuss the various structures of kinship.

- **Appendix 3**

Content

The bond of Kinship in Africa is reckoned through blood, marriage, or adoption. Kinship controls social relationships and regulates behavior. It binds families, clans and ethnic communities together. Although it varies from one community to another, most of them have kinship as the only bond of unity. It can be broken down into:

- (i) Family - comprises of both nuclear (father, mother, children) and extended (grandfathers/mothers, uncles, aunts, cousins, nephews, nieces, step-parents/sisters/brothers, in-laws, etc.
- (ii) Lineage - comprises of several extended families.
- (iii) Clan - comprises of various lineages.
- (iv) Age-set - this comprises of the guilds acquired during initiation ceremonies, in particular circumcision.

The above form the horizontal bonds of kinship that only incorporates the living. There are also vertical structures, which include the un-born and the departed members of a family or community. The vertical links unite people with the past and future descendants of the families and clans.

Note:

Each of these structures make provisions for the future and past generations in terms of physical and spiritual space. This is demonstrated in plans that people make for unborn children as well as elaborate funeral rites of incorporation. The departed members, in particular occupy a special ontological space in kinship bonds for they are continually seen as members of the living, only in another form. They are the living-dead.

Appendix 4

Question:

What are some of the observable changing patterns of the African family?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Trace your family root tree to the third generation. Are there any unusual characteristics you find in your family tree? What does this tell you about your family?

Appendix 6

Summary:

In today's discussion, we emphasize the importance of kinship bonds in African communities. These control social behavior and regulate relationships. The bonds formed by kinship structures are important for they unite the past and the future with the present.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words:

Ontology: the study of being and existence

Kinship: bonds of unity in Africa

Living-dead: departed members within African communities who are still remembered by the living

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

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Lesson Thirteen

Ontology: Kinship Systems and Social Obligations

Appendix I

Introduction

In lesson twelve, we discussed the bond of kinship in African communities. We observed that kinship systems in Africa serve as the strongest bond of unity that binds the living, the un-born and departed members of the family. In the current lesson, I will address the importance of the kinship bonds and social obligations of members to the community.

Appendix 2

1:2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Explain the importance of kinship structures in Africa.
- Analyze the role and function of kinship in controlling social behavior
- **Appendix 3**

Content

Within all the kinship structures, we find that members have certain obligations. They not only expect something from the structure, but are also expected to give in something in return to it. That way, both individuals and the structures all benefit and are strengthened. The bonds are also maintained.

The family (Household) - Father/mother/children - nuclear is the basic building block of the society. The individual has no real existence outside the family and the community. A person is only a part of the whole. The community moulds an individual to a person through the various rites of passage., hence the saying by Mbiti, " **I am because we are and since we are, I am.**"

Note:

Living in Africa is therefore being part of a family and a community where members have specific roles and obligations towards each other. For example, a father is the head, protector, and provider of the family. He is expected to dispense justice. A mother serves as a domestic (productive and reproductive) provider of the family and children as sources of domestic labor and defends the family and community when they are of age. They are a source of insurance for their parents in old age. Children also act as social comforts to a family, especially in propagating the family tree.

Traditional taboos exist to control activities of individuals to the society. All must adhere. Division of labor, in particular, is gender based and varies across Africa. At both families and communities, roles rarely interchange and at times, this may be taboo.

CLAN- a sub-division of the ethnic group. Some are patrilineal or matrilineal - Each clan has and knows its founder. This is often a legendary person or real historical person. The clan has its own principles and rule concerning life, that is, political, economic, social and religious practices. Many clans have their own clan symbols often referred to as **totems**. In some clans, marriage is allowed between members. They are referred to as **endogamous**. In others, marriage is strictly forbidden between the members. This is referred to as **exogamous**.

Note:

Clans are a concentration of various lineages, which in turn are a composition of several families. The family is the basic building block of the society. If it is interfered with by anything, the whole fabric of the society is shaken.

Appendix 4

Question:

Do you think the gender division of labor in Africa is valid? Should gender roles be exchanged at the family or community levels?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Select two families in your neighborhood. Check how roles are distributed within the household. Are there any observable deviations from the traditional African families? Analyze them.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In today's lesson, we have stressed the importance of two structures within kinship bonds, the family and the clan. We learn that individuals have certain obligations to the existing structures. On the other hand, both the family and the clan have certain expectations of its members. Each party must adhere for the smooth running of the society.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Endogamous/endogamy: describes types of clans where members are allowed to marry from within/ marriage within the clan members

Exogamous: refers to types of clans where members marry only from outside their clan/ marriage outside clan members.

Totem: special item (animal/plant) that clans associate with some mystical powers

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

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Lesson Fourteen

Rites of Passage

Appendix I

Introduction

In the last lesson, we addressed the relationship between kinship bonds and social obligations of members to the community. In today's lesson, I want to discuss the rites of passage in African communities. These important ceremonies mark the stages of development of an individual from one stage of growth to another.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Describe the significance of the rites of passage
- Identify the various components of the rites of passage
- Relate the components with a particular rite of passage

Appendix 3

Content

As we said earlier, life in Africa is rhythmic and marked in seasons. Similarly, it was thought that human life has rhythms, which are measured by rituals and initiation ceremonies. As each individual passes through a different stage or rhythm in his/her life, it would be marked by a different ceremony. These are referred to as the rites of passage. They ritualize the changes through which each person passages from the time before one is born until after death.

Examples of rites-

- Birth and naming ceremonies
- Initiation and circumcision
- Betrothal, wedding and marriage,
- Death & funeral rites.

Each rite has specific elements within it, which must be fulfilled. These are:

- (1) Symbolic structure: this marks the actions within the ritual, which symbolize the changes that are taking place in the rhythm of the candidates' life.
- (2) Value structure - the rites also convey the values which society wants to transmit about the new rhythm, which the candidate is entering. In this sense, the rites perform the function of education in cultural values.
- (3) Role structure - this introduces the candidate to the new role, which he/she will play in the society.

For example, initiation/circumcision, the cutting of the body (mutilation), shedding of blood, body marks, change of name, location etc. A person has to learn new values of adulthood like secrets of the community, boundaries, and issues to do with sex and marriage and family values. One is perceived to be an adult. New roles regarding to adult

life, in particular sex education must be taught. Issues to do with preparation for adulthood are taught mainly in the period of seclusion that accompanies the initiation ceremony.

Note:

There have been many observable changes in the rites of passage in Africa, particularly in the rituals accompanying the rites. While some significance of certain rituals remain, changing patterns of thought in the African systems has eroded some.

Appendix 4

Question

Do you think female circumcision in Africa is valid? Give reasons for your answer.

Appendix 5

Activity:

Identify one community in Africa. Select the rite of death and funeral rites. Analyze it from the structures mentioned above. Explain the significance of every stage.

Appendix 6

Summary:

This lesson puts emphasis on the significance of rites of passage in African communities. The rites are taken very seriously because, through them, important knowledge of both the family and the community are taught. The rites serve as an important facet of the education system and integration of members to the new stages in life.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Ritual: a ritual is a repeated and symbolic word or action (dramatization) directing attention to a place where the sacred enters life; thereby granting identity to participants in the drama, transforming them, communicating social meaning verbally and non-verbally.

Rite of passage: stages in life that ritualize different stages of an individual's growth.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

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Lesson Fifteen

Numinous/ Mystical Powers In African Religious Heritage

Appendix I

Introduction

In lesson fourteen, we discussed the rites of passage in African communities. These important ceremonies mark the stages of development of an individual from one stage of growth to another. In the following section, we will address two types of numinous powers that exist in African religion and culture. These form an important aspect of African religion and philosophy. In this lesson, I want to discuss the mystical force referred to as "*mana*".

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Define *mana*
- Identify the properties of *mana*
- Discuss its significance in African religion

Appendix 3

Content

African religion recognizes the presence of some mysterious power that is referred to as *mana* - This is a Melanesian word that refers to an impersonal power that is regarded with great fear. Mbiti calls it **mystical** power. He says that it is not fiction but a reality.

Note

***Mana* is mainly used for good or ill by a specialist in magic or in witchcraft (*Uganga/Uchawi*). Such people either apply it in their activities to protect their clients, that is by detonating it or to harm them.**

Mana is a power that ultimately comes or originates from God. This power is both visible and physical. Its presence can be felt during worship, or when used by some religious specialists, witchdoctors or herbalists. *Mana* is also invisible and mysteriously spiritual. The invisible power is primary. It can be seen when it is put to use by the special spirits or ancestors. This power is involved in the practice of magic & religion.

Appendix 4

What are some of the things that explain the presence of this power in the universe?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Have you encountered a witchdoctor or a person who has consulted one?, If so, find out how the principle of *mana* is manifested.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have discussed that mysterious power in the world called *mana*. We have observed that, *mana* is visible, physical and spiritual. It originates from God. *Mana* can be used by certain individuals in the community either for its betterment, or for destruction.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Mystical: a force or power above human understanding, often experienced when one comes into contact with the sacred

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

- Idowu, B.B. (1973), Africa Traditional Religion: A definition: SCM Press Ltd, London
Kenyatta, J. (1938) Facing Mount Kenya: Secker and Warburg, London
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Lesson Sixteen

Numinous/Mystical Powers In African Religious Heritage

Appendix I

Introduction

In the previous lesson, we discussed *mana* and its properties within African communities. We said that *mana* is a mysterious power that originates from God. In today's lesson, I want to address another numinous power found in African religion. This is referred to as taboo. Taboo is the oldest unwritten code of law that operates in Africa.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Define taboo
- Analyze meaning and principle of taboo
- Explain the function of taboo in African communities

Appendix 3

Content:

Taboo is a Polynesian word that refers to anything considered sacred and therefore, forbidden to be touched or used. In its religious sense, it is closely associated with '*mana*' or mystical power. The power of '*mana*' can be communicated and passed on to people, places, and polluted objects. It is this power that makes objects or people tabooed. Examples of tabooed persons are kings, chiefs, priests, medicine men and women etc. Places associated with God or spirits are **consecrated** and so, are tabooed. On the other hand, objects like blood, dead bodies, and some animals are taken to be taboo. Equally, certain social sanctions are put on menstruating women, nursing mothers, widows, and twins, all which are regarded as taboo. Taboo regulates morality and ethics by putting social sanctions on violators.

Note:

The principle of taboo operates on objects or circumstances that appear strange to the ordinary. It is mainly meant either to protect the tabooed person/place or issue; or to protect the society from the same.

Appendix 4

Question:

Why do you think taboos are so powerful in Africa?

Appendix 5

Activity

List five taboos in your community. Find out the effect and consequences of violating them.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have discussed the taboo. We have noted that taboo is one of the oldest unwritten code of law that regulated morality and ethics in African cultures. Taboo applies to people, places, and objects and social-religious issues. It is meant to protect people from incidences that may harm them.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Consecrated: set apart for some holy use.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

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Lesson Seventeen

Magical Powers

Appendix I

Introduction

In the previous two lessons, we have addressed two types of numinous powers in African society. These operate on the principle of the presence of mystical powers that exist in African religion and culture. This facet forms an important aspect of African religion and philosophy. In the following lessons, I will discuss the application of the numinous powers in various aspects of African beliefs and practices. In this particular lesson, I will discuss the aspect of magical powers in African culture.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Describe the principle of magic and magical practices
- Distinguish the various types of magic

Appendix 3

Content

In African cultures, humans often think that they can use the mysterious power at work in the world for their own ends. As I said earlier, this power is impersonal. As such, human beings need to know the technique by which they can gain control over the elemental powers of the universe.

Note:

Africans believe that this technique works automatically provided that the necessary taboos are observed and the ritualistic words are used. In magic, they see no need to submit to God. Humans need the power but want to gain control over it. It applies on the principle of "May my will be done".

Types: there are various types of magic. Examples are-

1. Homoeopathic/ imitative magic - This operates on the principle of similarity. Like produces like. For example, in rainmaking rites, water is spewed into the air to make rainfall by imitation, or clouds of smoke are made to rise to help the clouds gather around. A woman may also carry a doll in hope of reproducing a child that she has lost in sickness; spots may be pasted on the skin of a sufferer from a rash, and then washed off again. One can make an **effigy** or likeness of an enemy then destroy it. For example, by sticking needles or burning it with fire. By so doing, it is understood that the victim suffers.

2. Contagious

This works on the principle of touch. It is based on the notion that things once joined must remain so and can affect one another. Harmful charms can be made of a person's waste hair, nails, clothing, bath water, sleeping mat etc. Contiguity means touching something or someone else. In this type, an enemy's footprints /hair or clothes are identified. These are destroyed, for example, sticking a footprint with needles or thorns or dipping an enemy's item in poison.

These act in particular if accompanied by ritualistic words that are supposed to harm an individual.

Note:

Witchcraft (*Uchawi*)- is the application of bad magic mainly to harm people. Both males and females practice it, mainly at night. Females are termed as witches while males are called wizards.

Sorcerers are witches; and therefore, women. They operate at daytime. They use poison in their magic. Both sorcerers and witches are believed to disguise themselves into animals. They are perceived to be evil and enemies of the community.

Appendix 4

Question:

What is the impact of the practice magic in a community?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Select ten people from different ages and lifestyles. Ask them whether they believe in the practice of magic. Find reasons for their answers.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have observed that the practice of magic is based on the principle of the manipulation of mana. Special people, the magicians, mainly do this. There are several types of magic. In types of magic, people see no need to submit to God. Magic is a negative use of the mystical powers in the universe.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Effigy: an image made of someone for magical practices.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

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Lesson Eighteen

Protective Powers

Appendix I

Introduction

In lesson seventeen, we addressed magic and its impact in the society. We concluded that, magic applies the principle of the numinous powers in its negative manipulation to harm the society. Due to this misuse of power, Africans feel vulnerable to magical practices. Consequently, they need to protect themselves from an ontological disorder that may be caused by the practice of witchcraft and sorcery. The use of protective charms is the subject of my discussion today. These are mainly used to counteract evil in the society.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Discuss the types of charms in a given community
- Explain the relevance of protective powers in Africa
- Analyze the role and function of charms in Africa

Appendix 3

Content

CHARMS; The use of charms vary from one place to the next. The aim is to have protection from danger. Magicians who take powders from herbs believed to have magical powers give these. While doing this, the magician recites a magical formula, and then instructs the client on how to use the charm. He/she is to wear it on and never to part with it. Other forms of charms are made from animal skins or metals. They can either be worn or just put in specific places in one's environment. The wearing of charms is a form of magic especially to the wearer and the one who administers it.

Examples of Charms in the Gikuyu community

1. Hate or despising
2. Love
3. Defensive
4. Destructive magic/witchcraft
5. Healing
6. Enticing & attracting
7. Silencing & surprising
8. Fertility: Human & agricultural

Note:

It is only the wearer who knows the usefulness of the charm, otherwise it is meaningless to any other person. The ritual process makes the charms relevant.

Appendix 4

Question:

Do you think charms have any protective powers today?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Select another religion besides ARH. Find out whether there are any charms in that religion. Explain the presence or absence of charms in your chosen religion.

Appendix 6

Summary:

The belief in charms is wide spread in Africa. This is based on the fear of the misuse of mana by certain people to harm others in the community. It is based on the fear of magic, witchcraft and sorcery. Charms are perceived to offer that protective or curative power. There are different types of charms and these cut across all aspects of life. Africans feel the need for protection in all these fields of life.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Charm: an object used by an individual for protection from mystical powers

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

- Idowu, B.B. (1973), Africa Traditional Religion: A definition: SCM Press Ltd, London
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Lesson Nineteen

Specialists in African Religious Heritage: Healers & Rainmakers

Appendix I

Introduction

In the last section, we have been dealing with the practice of magic and witchcraft in African religion and cultures. This, we concluded, deals so much on the belief of a mysterious power in the universe that can be used by certain people in the society for positive or negative reasons. In the following lessons, I will be addressing the special people in African communities, referred to as specialists. The African conception of specialists in the society is based on the application of *mana* and the understanding that these people hold special vital power than others. Specialists must be trained; otherwise, misuse of '*mana*' can harm the people. These are people of good character. They are of many types. I am going to break their subject into several categories, which will be the item for discussion in the next few lessons. In this lesson, I will address the Healers and Rainmakers

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Define healers and rainmakers in Africa
- Explain the role and function of healers and rainmakers
- Analyze the principle used by these specialists in their activities.

Appendix 3

Content

Healers; herbalists

This category of specialists is concerned with diseases, sickness, and misfortune. They find out the cause of the problem that may be partially spiritual/physical. They use words and medicines, rituals and at times require the sick to offer a sacrifice.

Note:

Disease and misfortune are religious experiences, which require a religious or psychological approach to deal with them. Medicine practitioners also play the role of cleansers. For people already attacked by evil spirits and curses, they offer curative remedies. They are friends of the society.

Medicine is used to increase productivity and fertility. For example, in cases of **barrenness** and **impotence**, men and women consult the specialists for religious and physical healing. These people are also consulted in issues not related to health to guarantee success and maintain peace and harmony at both individual and community levels. Such cases are success in business, elections and exams.

RAINMAKERS

Their work is to make rain when it is needed, and to stop it if it is too much. They study the sky and signs of weather very carefully. They are likened to medicine people or **diviners**. They conduct rituals and sacrifices to persuade God to give rain. Often, they use rain stone's, burning rain leaves or water sprinkling in their rituals. This is seen as a form of magic where imitative method is used.

Appendix 4

Question:

Discuss the principle applied by these specialists.

Appendix 5

Activity:

Visit either one of the specialists mentioned above. Describe their relevance in the community.

Appendix 6

Summary:

Healers and rainmakers are important people in African communities. They diagnose the problem and address it accordingly. They are friends of the people for their activities increase productivity and guarantee continuity of life.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Barrenness: the inability to conceive in females

Diviners: people with special skills of foretelling the future

Impotence: the inability to father children in males

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

- Idowu, B.B. (1973), Africa Traditional Religion: A definition: SCM Press Ltd, London
- Kenyatta, J. (1938) Facing Mount Kenya: Secker and Warburg, London
- Mbiti, J.S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann. London
- Okot, P. Bitek (1974) African religions in Western Scholarship: Heinemann. Nairobi
- Parrider, E.G. (1974) African Traditional Religion: Sheldon Press: London
- Ray, B.C. (1976) African Religions: Symbols and the Community: Prentice Hall Inc. New Jersey

Lesson Twenty

Specialists in African Religious Heritage: Political Leaders Kings, Queens and Rulers

Appendix I

Introduction

We are still looking into the role and function of one category of specialists in African communities. In the previous lesson, we have addressed medical practitioners and rainmakers. We noted that these are friends of the community for they offer remedies in times of personal or communal calamities. In this lesson, I will address political leaders. This comprises of kings, queens and other political entities. Like other specialists, these people are perceived to have more power and hence must be respected. Several taboos revolve around them, for they are also consecrated to their offices.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Define the category of political leaders in the communities of Africa
- Explain their role and function in the society

Appendix 3

Content

Like other specialists in African communities, political heads are divine symbols of authority in the society. They are referred to as God's divine -and is considered holy. People must always speak well of them and give them due respect. Their subjects should not come near them or copy their living styles like clothes. Their authority is believed to come from God. In most communities, the political leader has the power of life and death over his/her people. Several taboos are associated with political leaders. The murder of a king, for example, is seen as a great disaster for the Kingdom and often kept secret until a new ruler is chosen.

Note:

Although kings, queens and other political leaders are revered in Africa, they are supposed to mind the welfare of their people. They lead them in times of crises and must make wise and quick decisions to avert danger and or disaster. They are also spiritual heads of their communities. As such, they must be people of high integrity.

Appendix 4

Question:

Discuss the activities of political leaders in African communities. Why do you think these people are crucial in a community?

Appendix 5

Activity:

Select one country in Africa. Find out how political leaders are chosen. Are there any social or religious obligations of that leader? Find out what is done to a leader who violates the rules.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In today's discussion, we have addressed the role and function of political leaders in Africa. These are important people in the society for they deal with both political and religious affairs of their communities. They are highly respected by their subjects, almost at the point of adoration.

- Describe the characteristics of religious specialists in Africa
- Explain the role and function of religious specialists in African communities
- Distinguish the different types of religious specialists in African communities
- Describe the process of acquiring office for each group.
- **Appendix 3**

- **Content**

(a) **MEDIUMS**: - a special group of religious specialists who act as a link between human beings and the dead or the spirits. This is done through spirit possession. In this, the specific spirit of a dead person gets into a living person; the medium. By so doing, the departed spirit communicates its wish to the living. In most cases, the communication involves warnings of some misdeed that the living have violated. The beating of drums or the singing of music, clapping of hands in a rhythmic manner induces the medium into a state of possession.

(b) **DIVINERS**- these work closely with mediums by the practice of divination. They use special stones, nuts, gourds, shells, and numbers, palm reading, water pot-reading etc. Their job is to see into things using their divine knowledge and ability, which other people do not have. Specifically, they look for wrong doers, lost articles, or discover causes of illness. Diviners are consulted as comforters, advisors, and judges in all sorts of problems and crises.

(c) **PRIESTS**- these sacred persons mediate between humans and the spirits, or humans and God. They offer sacrifices and prayers. At times, their function overlaps with the medical personnel. They are well trained. The training involves learning of the many prayers, rituals and sacrifices in African religion. While some receive special calling, others inherit the job.

Note:

They have to observe special taboos regarding food, sex, mixing with people, or wearing certain kinds of clothes when carrying out their priestly functions. They act as a religious symbol of God's presence among the people.

(d) **PROPHETS**- this is a rather rare category of people in the community. Where present, they acted as mediators between the people and God. They also mediated God's blessings to the people especially at planting, harvesting, initiation etc. Prophets have great spiritual authority. They also play the role of diviners in the sense that they foretell the future. The office of the prophet is **hereditary** and his successor is trained from birth. The symbols of his office are in most cases a- judgement seat, a black bull-skin, cloak, staff and a gourd of honey (Example derived from the Ameru of Eastern Kenya).

Note:

Prophets act as a religious symbol of God's presence among the people. They had unique character and qualities. Among these, they had to be born pure (no deformities), never murder (pure), good character and happily married. Besides, they must follow and obey all the customs, and never do anything harmful to people. They serve as judges for the can pronounce curses or blessings.

Appendix 4

Question:

What roles should a religious leader play at both the family and community?

Appendix 5

Activity:

List the characteristics of a religious leader in any given religion. Is there anything unique or extra ordinary you find in these people?

Appendix 6

Summary:

In today's discussion, we have addressed various categories of religious leaders in Africa. We have seen some of their roles and functions in African communities. These are important people in the society for they address religious aspects within their communities. They must be consecrated to their offices and must have specific qualities. They carry out the mission of the divine.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Hereditary: some trait acquired from one's parents.

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

- Idowu, B.B. (1973), Africa Traditional Religion: A definition: SCM Press Ltd, London
- Kenyatta, J. (1938) Facing Mount Kenya: Secker and Warburg, London
- Mbiti, J.S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann. London
- Okot, P. Bitek (1974) African religions in Western Scholarship: Heinemann. Nairobi
- Parrider, E.G. (1974) African Traditional Religion: Sheldon Press: London

Ray, B.C. (1976) African Religions: Symbols and the Community: Prentice Hall Inc.
New Jersey

Lesson Twenty-two

African Ethics, Evil, Justice Punishment

Appendix I

Introduction

We have finished with the series of roles and functions of specialists in African communities. In the last few lessons, I have been addressing several categories of specialists found in African religion and culture. Each of these has specific characteristics, role and function in the society. In conclusion, we observed that these are people perceived to have special powers. These people are also highly respected. In the following lessons, I will be addressing African ideas of evil, justice and punishment. This forms the bases of ethics and morality in ARH. Today's lesson addresses the concept of evil, justice and morality.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Explain the origin of evil in African religion
- Analyze the concept of evil in Africa

Appendix 3

Content

African mythology does not describe the origin of evil. It is recognized that good and evil exist in the world and that God is good. The Baluyia for example believes that the East symbolizes all that is good and the West all that is evil. Bukusu people claim that evil is produced by an evil divinity that is independent of God but comes from spirits. According to the Ashanti of Ghana, God created a possibility of evil, but did not create people in order to be evil.

Note:

In African religion, Human beings are responsible for the evil, which they commit.

African's moral standard is therefore based upon good character. This involves **chastity** before marriage, faithfulness in marriage, hospitality, unselfishness, kindness, and truthfulness, keeping promises and showing respect for the elderly. It is also man's duty to protect women. God judges hypocrisy, stealing and lies. Morality is guarded by the various taboos in the society. Morality is **anthropocentric**. It is the tradition of human society, which determines what is evil rather than God. Evil is judged by its effect upon society.

Note:

The greatest evil lies in the consequences of an act rather than in quality or nature of the act itself. So if the act causes shame to the family or clan it is more serious than if no shame results. So the idea of evil is often relative to its effect on society or to the shame that it causes.

Morality is relative. Under certain conditions, evil is not considered objectively evil. There is no idea of an objective moral standard, which applies, to all classes of people, as in the case of the Ten Commandments in the Bible. A deed is judged by virtue of who does it to whom and from what level of status.

Note:

Something is evil because it is punished. It is not punished because it is evil. Sin affects society and upsets its rhythm.

Appendix 4

Question:

What is the basis of morality in Africa? Do you think all evil deeds in the society carry the same weight? Give reasons for your answer.

Appendix 5

Activity:

Select five cases in the local law courts. Find the nature of the crimes committed and the punishment given. Do you think the punishment was proportional to the offence committed? Justify your views.

Appendix 6

Summary:

In this lesson, we have addressed African ideas of evil, justice and morality. We found morality in Africa is Relative. Punishment is based on the nature and type of a deed, as well as the motives of the offender. Some deeds may be more evil than others depending on the instability they cause to the society; for example, the rape of a child appears more shameful and offensive than robbery; especially if no murder is committed in the latter. There is therefore, no common rules that govern morality in African. Evil is judged by its effect on the society. .

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Anthropocentric: human based or centered

Chastity: Being pure in sexual matters

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Magesa, L. (1997) African Religion: The Morals of Abundant Life: Pauline Publications
Africa, Nairobi

Mbiti, J. S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann, London.

Mugambi, J.N.K. and A. Nasimiyu-Wasike (Eds.) (1999) Moral and Ethical Issues in African Christianity: A Challenge for African Christianity. Acton Publishers, Nairobi.

Lesson twenty-three

African Ideas of Punishment

Appendix I

Introduction

While still in the series of African ideas of evil, justice and punishment, we have discussed the concept of evil, justice and morality in Africa. In lesson twenty-two, I want to go further and discuss the ideas of punishment held by different peoples of Africa.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Explain the principle of punishment in African religion
- Discuss the origin of punishment
- Analyze the nature and function of punishment in Africa.

Appendix 5

Activity:

Find out from your surroundings the reasons that people have about suffering. What are the causes of terminal diseases among Africans? What views does your community hold about death?

Appendix 6

Summary:

Punishment is a way of dealing with evil in the world. In African religion, humans have the ability to choose to be moral. The inability to make wise decisions on moral values is liable to punishment. People could also be punished for offences they are not even aware of, since God's morality is mysterious. Africans have to worship and make sacrifices to appease God in order to avoid His wrath.

Something is evil because it is punished; it is not punished because it is evil. Evil is only present where there is punishment. However, misfortune is not always considered punishment. Often, it is thought to come from a spirit or from some other person using witchcraft to bring misfortune. So, misfortune is not always blamed on the sufferer.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Beastiality: having sex with animals

Misfortune: a series of problems that affect an individual

Mysterious: strange, beyond understanding

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

- Magesa, L. (1997) African Religion: The Morals of Abundant Life: Pauline Publications Africa, Nairobi
- Mbiti, J. S. (1969) African Religions and Philosophy: Heinemann, London..
- Mugambi, J.N.K. and A. Nasimiyu-Wasike (Eds.) (1999) Moral and Ethical Issues in African Christianity: A Challenge for African Christianity. Acton Publishers, Nairobi.

Lesson Twenty-four

Social Change in Africa

Appendix I

Introduction

In the previous lesson, we addressed African ideas of punishment. The aim was to understand the basis of morality in Africa, which as we found, is relative. In this lesson I want to discuss the subject of change in Africa. From what we have observed, certain aspects of African Religion and culture have basically been affected by the global change. Notably, culture is dynamic and keeps on changing from time to time. African traditional values are thus challenged by a whole host of different philosophies and ideas.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Analyze the levels of change in ARH
- Discuss the factors that have led to the change
- Discuss the impact of the change in ARH

Appendix 3

Content

Some scholars argue that changes, which have so far occurred in Africa, have not caused any radical differences in the social fabric, others note that, Africa, for better or for worse, has been caught up in the general world-wide revolution. This is noticeable in the fields of medicine, urbanization, and administration as areas in which our traditional society has been disrupted.

Note:

Changes may have occurred in daily life and technology, as well as in values. These may have changed individuals' lives but not the whole fabric of society.

Changes have been brought by:

- A. Education
- B. Science and technology
- C. Urbanization and social mobility.

We note that informal education has been replaced with the contemporary system, which is formal. Educational curriculum, boarding schools, teachers have brought most of this change, all having contradicting values with indigenous education. Education has also created a new social structure of up-educated to drop outs in education. The **hierarchy** goes on from primary to university. Leadership or government management is based on merit and ability, whereby the intelligent and well educated become leaders replacing the tribal system.

Note:

This change has had its effect in the society in the sense that, it has created unemployment and drop- outs in the communities.

Other change has been brought by science and technologies like industry, motor cars, roads, bridges, electricity, radio, television, telephones, etc. Modern medicine and farming can be done without mystical powers, i.e. using drugs and fertilizers. All these have an impact on both the individual and the communities.

Note:

Africans today have realized that culture is dynamic. They expect things to be different since modern technology is changing traditional African ideas.

The money economy has speeded up the change. It has commercialized agriculture, time, labor, movement, business, land etc. This has created a category of rich individuals and nations. The gap between these and the poor widens every day.

Note:

Traditionally, riches were a sign of God's blessing. Today people are less convinced by this belief.

The growth of big cities has also influenced or changed Africa. We find the concentration of power and facilities in the urban centers. These have a de-tribalising effect. Town people have been uprooted from their tribal backgrounds. Town life is temporary and individualistic; this has its own drawbacks.

Traditional life was small-scale. People lived in communities of the family clan or tribe, where they knew each other. Modern governments are now faced with the problem of transposing the characteristics of small scale living to the level of the large-scale modern state. Colonialism and neo-colonialism have been effected. Governments are straining to maintain national unity.

Appendix 4

Question:

Do you think African traditional values would have changed without external influence?

Give reasons for your answer.

What are some of the fields that have proved quite resistant to change in Africa?

Appendix 5

Activity:

**Take a list of five areas where observable changes have occurred in Africa.
Analyze the impact of these changes to the life of Africans?**

Appendix 6

Summary:

We have discussed the changes that have taken place in Africa. We find that the change has been brought about by various elements in the society. These are mostly external factors. We also note that, although change may have occurred in certain aspects of the society, some elements are harder and more resistant to change than others.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Hierarchy: levels of power from the top to the bottom

Individualistic: the act of wanting to be alone and do things alone

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Cox, H. (1965) The Secular City. Macmillan: New York.

Mugambi, J.N.K. (1989b) African Christian and Contemporary Christianity, Longman. Nairobi.

Twenty-five

Individual Change

Appendix I

Introduction

In lesson twenty-four, we addressed the subject of change in Africa. The lesson concluded that various dimensions of change have actually affected certain aspects of African Religion and Culture. We addressed the factors that have led to the change and the impact of change to the society. In this lesson, I want to address the levels of change within the individual. I will also discuss the impact of that change to the community.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Analyze the levels of change within an individual.
- Discuss the factors that have led to the change.
- Discuss the impact of the change to both the individual and the society.

Appendix 3

Content

1. Observably, change may occur to either an individual or society. It is in two ways;
(a) structural change; which, refers to the basic units of society - (nuclear family, extended, clan etc). The basic structural units of society still exist in Africa even if some of the details like gender roles have changed. (b) Organizational change - another area of group change that involves organization of the society - this affects the political and social systems, methods of democracy and marriage systems.

Changes within an individual have occurred in the following:-

- (a) Ultimate cultural coding - every individual belongs to a distinct social or national group. Each person has been influenced and shaped in his thinking and his/her emotions by the history, environment, and human traditions. A person accepts the code of behavior and outlook that his/her culture has implanted within him/her. This is very resistant to change.
- (b) Scale of values- this scale refers to the values one gives to the raising of children, owning land, getting educated etc. Values can be changed but not easily. For example, the rite of female circumcision has resisted change in some communities, while for others, it has been changed.
- (c) Home technology - food provision and technology (cooking, eating, preparing, preserving) sleeping, leisure habits and methods of obtaining fuel etc. Notably, a lot of change has taken place in Africa in the home technology.
- (d) Daily life - refers to clothes, transport, and organization of one's personal life. This has been the easiest to change.

Note:

Some parts of an individual's life are harder to change than others.

Appendix 4

Question:

Why do you think some aspects of an individual's life are more prone to change than others?

Appendix 5

Activity

Interview both your parents and grandparents. (If not available, look for other elders). Find out from them the changes that have occurred in the home technology and other fields mentioned above. Discuss the factors that have brought these changes. What is the impact of these changes?

Appendix 6

Summary:

We have discussed the changes that have taken place in an individual's life in Africa. We find that the levels of change are varied. While some aspects change rather quickly, others are quite resistant to change. All the changes observable in Africa have had drastic effect on the society.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Drastic: Sudden

Appendix 8

Further Reading:

Cox, H. (1965) The Secular City. Macmillan: New York.

Mugambi, J.N.K. (1989b) African Christian and Contemporary Christianity. Longman. Nairobi.

Lesson Twenty-six

Religious And Cultural Change

Appendix I

Introduction

In lesson twenty-five, we discussed the changes that have taken place in an individual's life in Africa. We find that the levels of change are varied. While some aspects change rather quickly, others are quite resistant to change. All the changes observable in Africa have had drastic effects on the society. In this last lesson, I want to address the changes that have occurred in aspects of religion in Africa. In the last century, foreign religions have really penetrated in Africa. Their teachings have affected certain core aspects of religious life, that , most Africans have been left at the cross-roads. However, irrespective of all these new faiths, we still find some specific elements of African religion that have resisted change.

Appendix 2

1.2 Objectives

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

- Analyze the levels of religious change in Africa.
- Discuss the factors that have led to this change.
- Discuss the impact of religious change at the individual and the society.
- Asses the future of African Religious Heritage

Appendix 3

Content

The aspect of religion has not been spared by the revolution of change that has been taking place in Africa. With the coming of the Arabs and missionaries to Africa, two new religions were introduced to Africans. These are Islam and Christianity respectively. These religions were spread at the expense of African beliefs and practices, which were highly condemned by the foreigners in particular, Christian missionaries. These did not only condemn African religion, but also aspects of culture, which they deemed demonic. Consequently, Africans started fighting their own cultures in the name of being converted. This has left most Africans confused and hanging in the balance.

Note:

God does not want us to be aliens to our culture but only aliens to sin.

Once converted, an individual goes through rejection of his/her own culture, later on he/she starts accommodating it, and finally engages in re-establishment of an identity. If he/she rejects his/her past culture wholly, he/she becomes a **fanatic**. If he/she accepts his/her own cultural coding fully, it leads to **worldliness**. The latter often leads to **secularism**, which has flourished in Africa. Secular people reject religion because religion has rejected their secular needs. To them, religion is socially irrelevant. It does not meet their social needs. Religion in Africa has to show that it can meet both the spiritual and the secular needs.

Note:

A person should strive for a more balanced identity. Understand a new religion and its relationship to your culture. Affirm or reject all that is wrong.

Appendix 4

Question:

Should people abandon their cultures to join other religions e.g. Christianity and Islam?
Discuss this question in relation to what you have learnt in the course.

Appendix 5

Activity:

Analyze your own life from when you started studying this course. List any benefits you found in the process. Do you think the course is relevant for African Universities? Discuss?
What do you think is the future of ARH?

Appendix 6

Summary:

We have reached the conclusion of this course. Besides other things, we have analyzed the continuity and change of African religious and cultural heritage. For certain, we have observed that some aspects of African Religion have remained constant while others have really changed. In particular, we have discussed the impact of all these changes to the society. This leaves ARH and the peoples of Africa to critically re-assess their religious tradition and re-affirm it. Those elements that have positive values should by all means be re-established, while at the same time discarding the outdated and retrogressive elements. The future of African Religion lies in the wisdom of differentiating the truth.

Appendix 7

Definition of Key words

Fanatic: the state of being over-religious

Secularism: A belief in secular/ material things as opposed to the sacred .

Worldliness: Not recognizing the presence of the sacred/opposed to being religious

Appendix 8

Further Reading

Cox, H. (1965) The Secular City. Macmillan: New York.

Mugambi, J.N.K. (1989b) African Christian and Contemporary Christianity, Longman.
Nairobi.